Free Public Real Estate Data Research Checklist

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Educational / research only. Always verify current public access and comply with site terms. Manual lookup preferred. No scraping behind logins. No paid APIs. Compliance-first.

Pre-Flight

- Confirm you are using only free, publicly accessible sources (official .gov preferred).
- No paid API keys or accounts required for basic research.
- Document the source URL and access date for every data point.
- Respect robots.txt and terms of use.
- Note data freshness (assessor data often lags; Census is multi-year estimates).

Step 1: Identify Location

- Obtain full address or ZIP code.
- Use free Census Geocoder: https://geocoding.geo.census.gov/geocoder/geographies/address (get county, FIPS, census tract, lat/long).
- Note jurisdiction details (county, state, city).

Step 2: County Property Records (Assessor / Recorder)

Search for official portals. Examples of free public access (verified as .gov):

- King County, WA: https://kingcounty.gov/en/dept/assessor/buildings-and-property/property-value-and-information/look-up-property-information
- Maryland SDAT (statewide): https://sdat.dat.maryland.gov/RealProperty/Pages/default.aspx
- Los Angeles County, CA: https://assessor.lacounty.gov/ (Property Search)
- Cook County, IL: https://www.cookcountyassessor.com/ (search portal)
- Many others: Search "[County Name] [State] assessor property search" or "property appraiser".

Retrieve (if public): owner name (where allowed), assessed value, tax amount, property type, square footage, year built, last sale date/price (varies by state). Screenshot or note the official URL and date accessed. Prefer direct .gov over third-party aggregators.

Step 3: Census Demographics & Housing

- Go to https://data.census.gov
- Search by census tract, county, or ZIP for ACS 5-year estimates: median household income, housing occupancy, median home value, housing units (tables like DP04, B25077, S2503).
- Record the ACS year (e.g., 2019-2023 or latest available).
- Free API at https://api.census.gov (optional free key registration).

Step 4: Flood & Hazard (Free)

- Use FEMA Flood Map Service Center: https://msc.fema.gov/portal/home (public viewer, address search).
- Determine flood zone for the address.
- Check state GIS portals (search "[State] GIS parcel viewer" or open data portal).

Step 5: Additional Free Sources

- data.gov: search "housing", "real property", "parcel".
- HUD User: https://www.huduser.gov/ (Fair Market Rents, housing data). FY2026 FMRs available free.
- FHFA House Price Index: https://www.fhfa.gov/data (downloadable HPI).
- Freddie Mac PMMS (educational rates only): https://www.freddiemac.com/pmms — as of 2026-11-05: 30-year fixed 7.18% (down 0.06 from prior week), 15-year 6.57% (down 0.03). Not a quote; check latest Thursday release. Source: freddiemac.com/pmms. Next expected 2026-11-12.
- USGS Authoritative Source Parcel Viewer (index of free parcel publishers): useful starting point to find county portals.
- OpenFEMA datasets (public, no login): https://www.fema.gov/about/openfema/data-sets — housing assistance, NFIP, disaster data.
- Local treasurer/tax collector sites for tax status (official .gov).
- OpenAddresses for address validation: https://openaddresses.io

Step 6: Compile & Document

- Create a simple one-page summary with sources, dates, and key findings.
- List all URLs accessed.
- Flag any data that required login or payment (do not use those for this research).
- Note limitations: data varies by county/state; some records require in-person or formal requests; always cross-verify.

Notes

Availability varies widely by jurisdiction. Prioritize official government sites. This checklist is a free draft foundation for a potential digital product (PDF, Notion template, or worksheet). Currently free. No revenue generated. For any future sale only after real buyer interest and further polish. Compliance: Public records only. Do not redistribute raw data in violation of source terms.

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